infidel backers. Shuja had made his frustration with the British widely known, but according to Herati the rebel overtures were nonetheless met with a firm rebuke from the Shah.

> The leaders of the uprising sent a deputation to His Majesty, saying: 'You are our monarch, and we seek your support in our struggle against this foreign occupation: please separate yourself from this tribe of foreigners!' His Majesty replied: 'Our rule is inseparable from the English, whose honoured guest we have been for thirty years; and even though their imposition of the worthless Uthman Khan as the Nizam al-Daula and Wazir has caused us much grief, yet we bear them no grudge: let what is to befall them fall also on us!' Having failed in their attempt to co-opt His Majesty, the rebels declared him an infidel, a kafir.[27]

In the absence of a Sadozai to lead them, the insurgents then turned to the Barakzais. There had been rumours for several weeks that Dost Mohammad's clever and ruthless son, Akbar Khan, had at last escaped from Bukhara. But in his absence the rebels were forced to turn to the most senior of his Barakzai cousins, Mohammad Zaman Khan, the man who had saved Mohan Lal's life earlier in the day. When he had first heard of the outbreak, Zaman Khan had sent his son Shuja, the Shah's godson, to Captain Trevor to offer his services.[28] Now, seeing the way the wind was blowing, he agreed to take on the leadership of the revolt, writing politely to Macnaghten that he had accepted the offer 'not from his own wish, but to prevent greater ills arising'. He said that he was prepared to become Wazir to Shuja and negotiate a British withdrawal by peaceful means. 'They elected Mohammad Zaman Khan Barakzai as their leader,' recorded the disapproving Herati, 'and he who was commonly known as the "rich nomad", a country bumpkin, now became the most powerful man in Kabul.'[29]

The two real leaders of the uprising were not forgotten: Aminullah Khan Logari was elected his Naib, or deputy (a title he proudly retained for the rest of his life), with Abdullah Khan Achakzai acting as the Commander-in-Chief of the rebel armies. A proclamation was issued: 'Nawab Mohammad Zaman Khan Barakzai, Ghazi, in kindness the flower of the times, and in religious devotion the wonder of the age, has been selected by the Muslims of all tribes, under the title of Amir of the Faithful and Imam of the Holy Warriors, and as such recognised by all.'[30] Soon after this, mullahs and malangs [dervishes] rushed through the streets of the city banging their drums, formally declaring a jihad.